refused. Just before leaving, Palit got through to Lieutenant Colonel Bhupinder Singh, the commanding officer of 22 Mountain Regiment at Bomdila.

At the Tezpur airfield, Kaul who had returned from his foray into the foothills saw off Thapar. He told Thapar that he had gone to Foothills Camp and had appointed the corps's chief engineer, Brigadier Madhav Rajwade, MC to collect as many stragglers and other troops as he could muster and take up a defensive position should the Chinese suddenly appear. Just as they boarded the Super Constellation IAF aircraft, Palit 'enumerated for him his corps' order of battle on the South Bank and stressed that he had sufficient forces there—logistically supported by a large, well-stocked supply and ordnance base at Gauhati—to foil any Chinese attempt to cross the Brahmaputra.'

Kaul had none of his staff officers with him, so Palit gave him his own notes, after which he boarded the aircraft. As they started to taxi out, Kaul was already making his way back towards Foothills Camp. There he learnt that 48 Brigade had abandoned Bomdila. The corps commander then issued orders for Gurbax Singh to hold Rupa at all costs and returned. He then made his way back to Corps HQ in Tezpur. Lying next to him were the notes made by Palit for the defence of the Brahmaputra Valley. These were now forgotten; instead the staff was asked to work out plans to evacuate Tezpur instead. It was quite dark by then. Across the subcontinent, the airwaves were carrying All India Radio's announcement—Bomdila had fallen!